wanted, I was confident of Sarabhai's field of influence across institutions. He asked me to go to the RBI office in Madras as soon as possible and meet Y T Shah. I did not even ask who Shah was; I packed a small bag and headed for the Trivandrum airport.

It was a hopping flight via Madurai; and it turned out to be literally so. The flight was so turbulent that at Madurai airport, all but two passengers alighted and told the airline that since they are not keen on dying they would take the road to Madras. I was one of the two passengers who remained on board to Madras. At the end of the journey, which continued to be turbulent, the pilot asked me if I wasn't scared.

'I was shit scared,' I told him, 'but it wasn't a tough decision to continue on board as getting to Madras late would be as bad as not reaching there.'

The pilot did not ask any further.

At the RBI office, which was as infamous as any government office for their lack of courtesy and abundance of delay, I was treated like a king. When I asked for Y T Shah, an officer said he was waiting for me. Later I realised Shah was a senior official. In an hour, they gave me $1,260.

'The name Sarabhai could move heaven and earth,' I told myself.

But when the moment came for me to board the flight from Trivandrum to Bombay, from where I was to fly to the US, I had a momentary hesitation. I had packed just one ragged suit and a few pairs of trousers and shirts. My wife and our nine-month-old son came to the airport. Looking at them, on my first voyage to the other side of the globe, I thought if it was worth it. Something told me yes.

Sheer delight awaited me on board Air India flight Annapoorna from Bombay to New York. I was in the economy class when Sarabhai, sitting in the business class saw me passing by. He left his seat and took one next to me till end of the journey. As the flight hopped from Bombay to Kuwait, Rome, London and New York, I saw a different Sarabhai—one more introspective and philosophical. He did speak of India's space dreams at great length, but they were punctuated by long spells of silence and then unfinished sentences about his family life. He did not elaborate much on